

Pahankanuwa Sermon #6

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

Author: Ven. Katukurunde Nanananda Thero

(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Anupubbenā medhāvī,
thokathokaṃ khaṇe khaṇe;
Kammāro rajatasseva,
niddhame malam attano.*

From:

Verse 239 from the Malavagga (Chapter on Impurity) of the
Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Today is the Vesak Full Moon Poya Day. Because three events—the birth, the enlightenment, and the passing away (*pariNibbāna of the Greatly Compassionate Fully Self-Awakened Father—occurred on a Vesak Full Moon Day like today, Vesak Full Moon Day is an extremely noble day for the Buddhist world. In fact, the Buddhist New Year is Vesak day—the Vesak day on which the Buddhist Era begins. Various people in the world have various concepts regarding a New Year. In the Western world, they have formed a notion of a year starting at the beginning of January. Astronomically, they have similarly formed a notion of a New Year. In the same way, we in the Buddhist world, commemorating the Buddha, consider this Vesak Full Moon Day as the New Year.

Therefore, for the Buddhist devotee who wakes up in the morning having understood this matter well and calling to mind the virtues of the Buddha, today is a beautiful day. Today is a peaceful day. Today is a pure day. Devotees offer

various kinds of colorful decorations, offerings, and tributes as a mark of respect and homage to the Greatly Compassionate One, who attained Buddhahood after fulfilling the difficult perfections (*pāramīs*) for an extremely long period that cannot be measured even by billions of aeons (*kalpas*), sacrificing his eyes, head, flesh, and blood, because the Buddha has pointed out to them the path to Nibbāna which extinguishes the suffering and fires of saṃsāra.

When decorating to pay this respect and homage, we must actually reflect that there are two kinds of decorations we can perform in honor of the Buddha: external decoration and internal decoration. External decoration refers to those decorations visible from the outside on Vesak day, such as flags, Vesak lanterns, pandols, and so on. Internal decoration means decorating one's own mind-stream by spending this day observing precepts (*sīla*), listening to the Dhamma, and practicing meditation (*bhāvanā*), thereby cultivating those virtues pointed out by the Buddha within one's own mind. Thus, that is internal decoration. Furthermore, when considering offerings (*pūjā*), the Buddha Himself pointed out that we can pay respect and homage to the Buddha through two kinds of offerings: material offerings (*āmisa-pūjā*) and practical offerings (*paṭipatti-pūjā*). Material offerings mean offering oil, flowers, lamps, incense, food and drinks, medicinal beverages, etc., to the Buddha. Practical offering means practicing those virtues of virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) which constitute the path leading to Nibbāna pointed out by the Buddha. Between these two kinds of offerings, the Buddha praised practical offering (*paṭipatti-pūjā*) as the more noble offering. Thus, the faithful Buddhist devotee gradually directs the program that begins with external decoration towards internal decoration.

Likewise, the beginning made with material offerings is gradually oriented towards practical offerings. Indeed, the Buddha always admonished us and advised us to systematically bring about development within ourselves in this manner, both regarding those decorations and regarding offerings. A story that makes this matter very clear to us, a short, simple story, is given in the Dhamma commentaries as the background story of the verse we mentioned earlier. One day, a certain brahmin, a faithful brahmin—who must have had some degree of faith in the Saṅgha—came to the place where the monks gathered in the morning to drape their robes before entering the village for alms-round, and stood there watching out of idle curiosity. Because the grass had grown very high at that place and there was morning dew, the brahmin saw that when the monks draped their robes, the corners of their robes got wet with dew. Seeing this, this lay devotee thought, "I must clean this place a bit." After the monks had left, he brought a hoe, cleared the grass there, and prepared a circular area like a small threshing floor.

On the second day too, this person came and stood watching when the monks were entering the village for alms-round, probably to see if there was any shortcoming in the work he had done. While watching like that, he noticed that because the grass had been removed there, there was now dust. Seeing dust rising and staining the corners of the monks' robes as they draped them, after the monks had left, this lay devotee brought white sand and spread it, eliminating the dust. On the following day, he came to the same place and stood watching in the same manner. On that day, the sun was shining intensely early in the morning. Seeing the monks sweating due to the heat of the sun, he thought, "I must make a small shelter here." After the monks left, he prepared a small shed, a shelter, there. Coming again another day, he stood watching; on that day, it was raining heavily. Seeing the monks suffering due to the rainstorm, he thought, "I must build a small hall here." Thus, having built a small hall there for the monks to gather during their alms-round, he then thought, "Now I must offer this hall to the Saṅgha led by the Buddha." He invited the Buddha and the Saṅgha—it was not a grand place—and having conducted the Saṅgha around that hall, he offered an alms-meal. Before the appreciation of merits (*anumodanā*), that devotee declared to the Buddha: "Venerable Sir, Blessed One, it was in this way that I began this great meritorious deed, very humbly. First, as mentioned, I cleared the grass and cleaned a small space like a threshing floor. Next, I sprinkled some sand there. Next, I made a small shed there. Next, I built a small hall in this way, and now I have performed an alms-giving meritorious deed as well."

On that occasion, praising him, the Buddha declared to the brahmin: "Indeed, brahmin, a wise person, from moment to moment, little by little, by performing wholesome deeds, removes all the rust of defilements from his own mind-stream." Declaring this, He uttered the verse we mentioned earlier. Indeed, that verse is a very simple one. Furthermore, it is a verse so valuable that anyone can adopt it as a motto for their life, memorizing it and using it as an exemplary guide. It is a verse found in the *Malavagga* of the *Dhammapada*.

Anupubbena medhāvī

thoka-thokam khaṇe khaṇe

kammāro rajatasseva

niddhame malam attano

The general meaning of this: "*Medhāvī*" means the wise person, the intelligent person. "*Anupubbena*" means gradually, step-by-step. "*Thoka-thokam*" means little by little. "*Khaṇe khaṇe*" means from moment to moment. "*Kammāro rajatasseva*": "*Kammāro*" means the smith. Here it refers to a

gold or silversmith. "*Rajatasseva*" means in silver, as one does with silver. "*Attano malam niddhame*" means just as the smith removes the rust of silver, the "*medhāvī*", that wise person, the intelligent person mentioned before, removes the rust of defilements in his own mind-stream. This is the meaning of that verse. Whenever the Buddha uttered a verse, even if it was a four-line verse, every single word carries an extremely profound meaning. It fits together so perfectly, and the verse is structured with such amazing organization that not even a single word can be removed. Moreover, within every such verse, there is a spiritual power sufficient for someone to realize Nibbāna.

Such a valuable taste of liberation (**vimutti-rasa**) is present in every single one of those verses. Now, if we reflect a bit deeply on the words we mentioned in this verse: "*Medhāvī*" is used for people whose situational wisdom is naturally strong from birth, and whose wisdom has matured through *saṃsāric* experience—even if they do not possess much academic learning. Such is the "*medhāvī*" person. The word "*anupubbena*" is an extremely valuable word—"orderly" or "step-by-step". It displays systematic progression. A special characteristic of this Dhamma is systematic progression. There is an amazing systematic progression in this Dhamma. If the Buddha pointed out any category of Dhamma, they fit together perfectly like the links of a chain. Furthermore, on one occasion, the Buddha declared to the lord of asuras named Pahārāda: "Just as, Pahārāda, the great ocean has a gradual slope, a gradual slant, a gradual inclination, with no abrupt precipice; in the same way, Pahārāda, in this Dhamma-Vinaya, there is gradual training, gradual performance, gradual practice, and no abrupt penetration of final knowledge." Thus, the Buddha declared, comparing the Dhamma of this entire Dispensation, this path of practicing the Dhamma, to the great ocean.

The great ocean—as you devotees know—the seashore is a very beautiful place where even a small child can pick up seashells. Next, as one goes a little deeper, one can splash in the waves. It gradually becomes deeper. Going further inside, it is extremely deep. In the same way, in the path of practice found in this Dispensation, anyone can approach and make a start at their own level. There is a nature of the Dhamma itself drawing one in systematically, step-by-step, from one stage to another. So, when speaking of profound things, this entire Dispensation, or the path of Dhamma, the path of practice, is compared to the great ocean, in consideration of its depth. In some other instances, where this Dhamma is shown as something that goes upward little by little, towards higher things, the simile used is a flight of stairs or a ladder. Just like climbing a flight of stairs, this Dhamma leads one upward step-by-step. Thus, the simile of the great ocean shows the depth—going deeper little by little. Similarly, if it is something like a flight of stairs climbing to a mansion, one climbs it step-by-step to reach

the top. It is this amazing feature of the Dhamma that is shown by this word "**anupubba**"—gradual/orderly sequence. Step-by-step. It carries one along from one to another, implying systematic progression, connected to each other.

Next, "**thoka-thokam khāṇe khāṇe**". These few words also possess great depth. At first glance, they seem very easy and simple to understand. But the meaning underlying them is extremely valuable. "**Thoka-thokam**" means little by little. "**Khāṇe khāṇe**" means from moment to moment. If we examine the meaning of these words: little by little, or systematic progression. If one said "just a little", there is no systematic progression. When saying "little by little", a systematic progression is felt. If one said "just a moment", there is no systematic progression. When saying "from moment to moment", there is systematic progression. In this way, what is shown here, what is offered to the world here, is a certain "perception of possibility" (**hakī saññāva** / sense of "I can"). This feeling is absent in many people. Now, if we speak to someone about listening to Dhamma, meditating, or other Dhamma activities, especially regarding the Dhamma, in this day and age, what we often hear is, "Where is the time for such things? We have so much work. Where can we find time to do these? We don't even have time to breathe."

They utter various complaints of this sort. The best medicine for such people is what the Buddha has shown here: "**thoka-thokam khāṇe khāṇe**"—little by little, from moment to moment. This practice, or rather, this formula, this fundamental principle, is applied in the world in various ways to worldly things as well. As you devotees know, there is the "savings movement". No one has money to throw away, no surplus money, but everyone, thinking of their children, thinking of their future emergencies, saves little by little, whenever opportunity arises. A big work from a small beginning. The Dhamma path is also like this. Instead of wasting time by saying "there is no time, we have so much work", the Buddha gives the idea here that one can make a small start regarding these wholesome Dhammas (**kusala-dhamma**) and systematically carry out development.

He provides a perception of possibility to the world with these few words: "**thoka-thokam khāṇe khāṇe**". Understanding it wrongly, one must not do just a little and think that is enough. Little by little. For the person who can do a little, they can bring a great deal closer through that little. If they do not engage even a little towards it, they will never be able to do it at all. Likewise, if one uses one moment correctly, that person can carry it forward from moment to moment. Now we know that a great river, which goes towards the sea making a great sound, sometimes begins from the collection of a few drops of water falling from a roof. In this way, everything gathers together and eventually becomes a massive thing. In another such place, in the Dhammapada itself, the Buddha has shown

another very appealing simile, also on an occasion when speaking about meritorious deeds.

Udabindunipātena

udakumbhopi pūrati

pūrati bālo pāpassa

thoka-thokampi ācinam

"Do not underestimate merit, thinking 'this small merit will not come to me.' Do not think lightly of it, do not look down on it." The simile given next is: "*Udabindunipātena udakumbhopi pūrati.*" When it rains and water trickles down from the roof drop by drop, if a pot is placed there, after some time the pot fills up. "*Udabindunipātena.*" by the falling of water drops, "*udakumbhopi pūrati*" even a water pot is filled. According to that, following that, one can think: "*pūrati dhiro puññassa thoka-thokampi ācinam*". "*Dhīra*" means the wise person. That wise person, the intelligent person, "*thoka-thokampi ācinam*"—the word "*thoka-thokam*" is used—"little by little". Gathering it little by little, "*pūrati puññassa*" becomes filled with merit. Thus the Buddha declared. Drawing from that, we can understand that these few words, "*thoka-thokam khaṇe khaṇe*", are a very valuable set of words.

Let us also reflect on the simile given next: "*kammāro rajatasseva*". We said "*kammāra*" is used here, meaning a smith, not a person who beats iron, but one who works with gold and silver. We generally call him a goldsmith. But the simile given here is about silver. That too has been declared by the Buddha with a certain meaning. As you devotees know, silver is a substance with a beautiful white brilliance. A white thing. But the situation regarding this white thing is what is said here: "*kammāro rajatasseva niddhame malam attano*". Yet, rust has formed on this silver. When a goldsmith finds a piece of silver covered in rust, he cannot remove its dirt all at once according to the stated principle. Those who work with gold and silver know that they work with gold and silver in a systematic way—heating it little by little, cooling it, allowing it to rest for a while, and so on. In that very same way, just as the smith systematically, little by little, from moment to moment, removes the rust from silver, "*attano malam niddhame*"—one removes the rust of defilements that has accumulated in one's own mind-stream for a long time in saṃsāra. This is what the Buddha pointed out in that verse.

Thus, through this, besides the perception of possibility, a still deeper meaning is brought out. There is no need to say afresh that rust has formed on our mind-

streams; we know, even without a Buddha to tell us, that it is rusted. We suffer from it. Sometimes, the nature of that rust—how powerfully it has rusted—is what the ordinary person does not know. That is what the Buddha brings to light. But a more valuable fact is that beneath that rust, there lies a certain brilliance. That is a fact that brings great enthusiasm and courage to the world. The Buddha, on one occasion, declared this nature of the mind in an amazing manner, in a way no other teacher had ever declared: that there is a natural brilliance in the mind, and that it has been covered by the rust of defilements.

"Pabhassaramidaṃ bhikkhave cittaṃ, tañca kho āgantukehi upakkilesehi upakkiliṭṭhaṃ. Taṃ assutavā puthujjano yathābhūtaṃ nappajānāti, tasmā assutavato puthujjanassa cittaabhāvanā natthīti vadāmi"

"Monks, this mind is luminous. Bright. Radiant. But '*tañca kho āgantukehi upakkilesehi upakkiliṭṭhaṃ*'—yet, this mind is defiled by adventitious, externally coming impurities, by adventitious defilements. '*Taṃ assutavā puthujjano yathābhūtaṃ nappajānāti*'—the ordinary worldling (*puthujjana*) who lacks Dhamma knowledge does not know this fact as it really is, in accordance with reality. '*Tasmā assutavato puthujjanassa cittaabhāvanā natthīti vadāmi*'—therefore, that ordinary worldling who lacks Dhamma knowledge does not show interest in mental cultivation (*citta-bhāvanā*), in meditation." Next, the other side is shown:

"Pabhassaramidaṃ bhikkhave cittaṃ, tañca kho āgantukehi upakkilesehi vipparamuttaṃ. Taṃ sutavā ariyasāvako yathābhūtaṃ pajānāti, tasmā sutavato ariyasavakassa cittaabhāvanā atthīti vadāmi"

"Monks, this mind is luminous. There is also an occasion when it is liberated, freed from those external defilements. The instructed noble disciple (*ariya-sāvaka*) who has Dhamma knowledge knows this fact as it really is. Because of that, for such an instructed noble disciple who has Dhamma knowledge, there is mental cultivation. That person engages in meditation, the Buddha declared." Accordingly, we can understand that this is a matter that gives immense courage to the world: that there is a natural, inherent brilliance, a luminosity, in our mind-stream, and that it is possible to bring out that luminosity. If we begin to remove this rust systematically, little by little, from moment to moment, then one day, according to the power one has accumulated continuously throughout saṃsāra and also according to present effort, even those supramundane states, those deep and extremely pure states that an ordinary person cannot even think of, can be brought about; mental purity can be attained. This is what is brought out for us in this verse.

Next, the course of action for this has also been pointed out by the Buddha in various ways on various occasions. In particular, this is a simple simile. A place where the Buddha showed with a simile that even a small child can understand is the simile shown to the young Venerable Rāhula regarding how to purify this mind, and the advice given accordingly.

On one occasion, the Buddha asks the novice Rāhula, "**Kiṃ maññasi Rāhula kimpāṭiyogo ādāso**"; "What do you think, Rāhula, what is the purpose of a mirror?" He asks what a mirror is for, just as one would ask a small child. Then Venerable Rāhula replies, "**Paccavekkhaṇattho bhante**" "Venerable Sir, it is for looking at closely and examining." A mirror is there for looking at oneself carefully. Next, then the Buddha, drawing upon the simile, declares: "**Evameva Rāhula**,"—here, the word "**paccavekkhitvā**" mentioned earlier was inserted. "**Paccavekkhitvā**" means turning back and looking carefully; it has the meaning of reflecting with wisdom.—"In that very same way, Rāhula, reflecting with wisdom, **paccavekkhitvā paccavekkhitvā**—reflecting again and again, bodily actions must be done. Reflecting with wisdom on actions done by body, reflecting again and again with wisdom, they must be done." In the same way, regarding actions done by speech and actions done by mind, He declared this method of purifying the mind.

Next, He explains in further detail: "Rāhula, if you now have to do some work by body, before doing it, reflect, review—using the word **paccavekkhitvā**. Just like looking into a mirror, look at that action, looking with wisdom. Reflect with wisdom: 'This action that I am about to do, will it lead to my own harm? Will it lead to the harm of others? Will it lead to the harm of both of us?' Reflect in this way beforehand. When reflecting like that, if you realize, 'If I do this action, there will be such-and-such results, it will turn out badly for me, it will turn out badly for others, it will turn out badly for both sides,' then do not perform that action. That is before doing it. Likewise, while doing it—if by some chance in the initial stage you did not realize it, and you are carrying it out. But, even while carrying it out—the Buddha declares next—even while doing it, reflect in the same way. Just like looking into a mirror, reflect with wisdom on that action: 'If I carry on with this work in this way, will it be harmful to me? Will it lead to my downfall? Will it be harmful to others? Will it be harmful to both sides?'... If you realize so while carrying it out, you must abandon it right there on the spot, you must stop it right there, the Buddha declared. If you realize, 'No, this action I am carrying out is not harmful to me, it is indeed good for me, it is for my benefit, it is for the benefit of others, it is for the benefit of both sides, no harm is caused,' then carry on with that action, He pointed out in that way. That is while doing it. Not only that, but also after doing it. There are some actions that one does not understand before doing them, nor while doing them, but it is only after doing them that their true

nature is understood. Therefore, even after doing it, reflect in this very same way—examine it. 'If I did some action by body, did that action lead to my harm, my downfall? Did it lead to the harm of others? Did it lead to the harm of both sides?' If it was so, if you realized so, on that occasion—nothing can be done about it now—but the practice pointed out by the Buddha there is a method belonging to the Saṅgha. That is, confessing, 'Alas, such a mistake has been committed by me,' to the Teacher Himself, that is, to the Buddha, declaring it as a confession of an offense. Or else, going to one's other senior monks and declaring, 'A mistake, a slip, has occurred from me,' and promising, 'I will not do such a thing again.' That is what is called restraint in the future (*āyati-saṃvara*). One resolves not to do it again. In this way are actions done by body. In the same way, by that same principle, by that analogy, reflect also on actions done by speech—before doing, while doing, and after doing. Likewise, actions done by mind. Actions done by mind are thinking about various things. One must reflect on that too: 'Are these thoughts, this stream of thoughts, for my own good? Are they for the good of others? Are they for the good of both sides?' In this way, the Buddha pointed out that principle of Dhamma on that occasion, drawing from the simile of the mirror."

Next, He declares it as a natural law (*dhammatā*): "Rāhula, whatever ascetics and brahmins in the past purified their bodily actions, purified their verbal actions, purified their mental actions, they all did so according to this very principle, this method. Whatever ascetics and brahmins in the future will bring about purity in their actions of body, speech, and mind, they will do so according to this method. Ascetics and brahmins of the present time also do so according to this method." Thus, the Buddha declared that sutta discourse to Venerable Rāhula.

The mirror taken here is very useful for us. You devotees know about mirrors. There are mirrors in houses. Sometimes there are full-length mirrors in houses. But they only show the body. This is not a mirror that shows the body—it is a Dhamma-mirror. It is a mirror that shows the mind. Through this, this Dhamma is entirely a mirror that shows the mind. It shows the impurity of the mind. But through this analogy, we can understand: now, when combing hair, preparing the face, grooming oneself, etc., before doing so, one looks into the mirror to see if there is any place to adjust on the face or hair. One looks while doing it too. Even after doing it, one looks back to see if there is any shortcoming in how well one has dressed.

In that very same way, one must look into this Dhamma-mirror. According to the principle shown in the Dhamma, that story of wholesome and unwholesome (*kusala* and *akusala*) was spoken of there in terms of harm to others, harm to

oneself, harm to both sides, and so on. If it leads to harm in that way, it is unwholesome (*akusala*). If it does not lead to harm, it is wholesome (*kusala*). If it leads to good, it is wholesome. You devotees can easily understand that. In this way, this is a Dhamma-mirror; this Dhamma is entirely a mirror. So much so, a female Elder (*therī*) who attained Arahantship, an Arahant Nun, declared regarding her direct realization: "*dhammādāsaṃ apekkhitvā*"—"I looked at my face in the Dhamma-mirror." Looking at the face there means looking at the mind. "I adjusted these by looking into the Dhamma-mirror," she said.

Through that, we can understand that the advice given by the Buddha in the sutta discourse also helps us in our day-to-day practical lives. The biggest problem for everyone is finding time. Next, how to do this—the perception of possibility is not there. Likewise, how to make a start, how to carry it on.

We have found such good advice in these sutta discourses. Similarly, on another occasion, the Buddha delivered a sutta discourse containing a highly valuable simile.

There is a sutta called the "*Accharāsaṅghāta*" Sutta. Devotees, "*accharāsaṅghāta*" means the snap of fingers. You devotees know what finger-snapping is. Now, catching the thumb and the middle finger, one makes a small sound, a snap, on certain occasions. Exorcists and such also snap their fingers when doing rituals, or when they want to drive away a demon. But here, the Buddha in this discourse intends the time it takes to snap a finger. Very little time is spent on this. It implies a mere moment. In the *Accharāsaṅghāta Sutta*, the Buddha preaches: "Monks..." He addresses the monks, but He is informing the beings of the three worlds of this matter. "If, for the duration of a finger-snap, for even that brief moment, some monk develops a mind of loving-kindness (*mettā*), even within that brief duration of a finger-snap, regarding such a monk, I declare that he acts according to the Teacher's instruction, follows the Teacher's advice, and does not consume the almsfood provided by the world in vain." He declares him to be one who does not leave the development of absorption (*jhāna*) empty, who does not let it go to waste, and who lives without neglecting meditation. That is, even for a brief moment, a brief moment like a finger-snap, if someone develops a mind of loving-kindness, that too, in a small measure, is a form of absorption (*jhāna*). Even in a small measure, it is practicing according to the advice pointed out by the Buddha. Moreover, because of that very thing, some strength of monkhood is obtained from it, a value is added to it. That is why it was declared that he is worthy of consuming the alms-meal.

From that, one should not wrongly think that meditation should be restricted only to a brief duration like a finger-snap. But what is shown here is that if someone starts with a brief duration like a finger-snap, that person can carry that path of practice forward. Now we know that those who do great works in the world are those who obtained time from such brief moments. If the mind is trained to do a valuable work in a brief moment, that person, in the midst of doing their work, can recollect the Buddha's advice, "I have the time of a finger-snap here, don't I? Can't I apply that to meditation?" and travel on that path. In that way, He spoke about that mind of loving-kindness. Next, "If, monks, for the brief duration of a finger-snap, someone develops the perception of *Anicca* (Impermanent), reflects on *Anicca* (Impermanent)—that is, the meditation on *Anicca* (Impermanent). Reflection on *Anicca* (Impermanent) is insight (*vipassanā*). Next, similarly, if they contemplate the perception of *Dukkha* (Suffering), the nature of *Dukkha* (Suffering) in this saṃsāra—for everything that is *Anicca* (Impermanent) is *Dukkha* (Suffering). Next, if they contemplate that this painful thing is *Anattā* (Not-self), if they practice the recollection of death (*maraṇasati*), if they develop the recollection of the Buddha (*buddhānussati*), the recollection of the Dhamma (*dhammānussati*), the recollection of the Saṅgha (*saṅghānussati*)... if some monk practices these meditations even in a small measure, for the duration of a finger-snap, I declare that monk to be one who acts according to the Teacher's instruction."

From this sutta discourse too, we can understand, here too He provides the "perception of possibility." He provides a perception of possibility to the three worlds. This matter of time like a finger-snap—now we took the simile of the "exorcist". The similes given by the Buddha are extremely profound, extremely meaningful. Now we know, just as exorcists sometimes snap their fingers to drive away demons, here, by maintaining a wholesome mind for a brief moment, for the duration of a finger-snap, one creates an opportunity to remove the "demon of defilements", or rather, that rust of defilements. In that way, what is shown there too is the value of generating a "perception of possibility" in one's daily life and engaging in these activities—as shown by the Buddha.

So, if one is to do this kind of work, there is something else that must be used as an aid. We are presenting what can practically help you, these Buddhists, in a practical way. One must also understand the importance of this kind of work. The Buddha has often brought this to light on many occasions. In this Dispensation, these are known as the bases of urgency (*saṃvega-vatthu*). All vehicles and such have a certain speed. Various fuels are added to build up this speed—whether "regular" or "super"—things of that sort are added. In the same way, a certain speed is required to travel this journey of the Dispensation. That speed is called *saṃvega* (spiritual urgency). Things that act as fuel for that speed are

called *saṃvega-vatthu* (bases of urgency). What are these *saṃvega-vatthu*? They are not things that can be touched with hands. Nor are they things that can be bought. But these matters are:

Jāti jarā vyādhi cuti apāyā

atīta anāgata vaṭṭa dukkhaṃ

idāni āhāra gavesi dukkhaṃ

saṃvegavatthū imāni aṭṭha

Reflecting according to the word of the Buddha, we have been born in this saṃsāra for an endless time; reflecting on this *Jāti* (Birth), or rather, this very *Jāti* (Birth), this very life—how terrifying an event is *Jāti* (Birth)? Mothers know this, even if the young child does not. Next, after being born, is there not *Dukkha* (Suffering) right from there? This *Jāti* (Birth) is *Dukkha* (Suffering); thus, even without a Buddha saying so, it is something the world must understand. In this day and age, they consider it something to celebrate. It is a matter for lamentation—obtaining this *Jāti* (Birth). For an extremely long time in saṃsāra, we have committed this foolishness. Due to that very *Jāti* (Birth), the first gift received next, the birthday gift, is death. If one is born, death is certain. The next station on the path to death is *jarā* [decay/aging]. From *Jāti* (Birth)—*Jāti* (Birth), *jarā*. Next, *jarā* [decay/aging] is the second *saṃvega-vatthu*. *Jāti* (Birth), *jarā*, next *vyādhi* (illness); as one goes to *jarā*, as the body decays, illness draws closer to assist it—diseases. Next *cuti* (passing away), next ending in death. Thus, *Jāti* (Birth)—birth. Next, growing old, what is called *jarā*. Subject to *jarā*. Next, diseases. Next, death. Next, reflecting on the past according to the Buddha's word, how much *Dukkha* (Suffering) have we suffered in past saṃsāra? Next, if we do not see Nibbāna in the future, if we do not realize Nibbāna, for how long a time in the future—according to the Buddha's word—the Buddha declared that we travel in this saṃsāra from an extremely long, beginningless time. Therefore, in the future too, we will have to suffer *Dukkha* (Suffering) in that way. The *Dukkha* (Suffering) of the round of existence (*vaṭṭa-dukkha*) in past and future. In this saṃsāra, in this spinning in one place, the foolishness involved, the *Dukkha* (Suffering) arising due to this—next, one must reflect on that daily. Likewise, the effort made to seek food in this life. How much *Dukkha* (Suffering) is that? One must reflect on how animals strive for this food. Perhaps for wealthy people, obtaining food might seem like a small thing. Sometimes, as Venerable Anuruddha in the past declared regarding the "arising of rice", as if food just appears on the table. But how much does one toil throughout the day for this bit

of food? That too is *Dukkha* (Suffering). In this way, these *saṃvega-vatthu*, regarding life in this saṃsāra, the nature of *Dukkha* (Suffering) in saṃsāra, must be reflected upon constantly. Reflecting according to that *saṃvega* (spiritual urgency), then, the small space one gets—just as we save a little, thinking of emergencies and children—one must strive to apply that brief moment to a meritorious deed, to Dhamma, to meditation.

It is due to the lack of generating such *saṃvega* (spiritual urgency) that ordinary Buddhists gradually move away from the Dhamma. Because of that, *Dukkha* (Suffering) increases in this world. And they accumulate *Dukkha* (Suffering) for the next world too. Thus, this Buddha Sasana is the work, the program of removing a multitude of rust. The Buddha pointed out this rust. There are various kinds of rust in the world, but more than all those kinds of rust, the real rust is shown as:

...Malā ve pāpakā dhammā asmiṃ loke paramhi ca

tato malā malataraṃ avijjā paramaṃ malaṃ

In the world, both in this life and the next, the real rust is indeed evil deeds. Committing sins is a huge rust in the world. A well-known type of rust in the world. Next, even more than that, "*tato malā malataraṃ*"—the greatest rust of all is: "*avijjā paramaṃ malaṃ*"—ignorance (*avijjā*), what is called non-knowledge, the lack of knowing the Four Noble Truths, that foolishness, that ignorance. The ignorance present in saṃsāric beings. That indeed is the greatest rust. Thus, it was to cut away this rust that the Buddha pointed out the Noble Eightfold Path as the Middle Path (*majjhimā paṭipadā*). There too we have a gradual program. What is this Noble Eightfold Path? Often, it remains restricted to words. Many people do not understand the value found here. An amazingly wonderful Dhamma-path is present here: *sammā-diṭṭhi, sammā-saṅkappa, sammā-vācā, sammā-kammanta, sammā-ājīva, sammā-vāyāma, sammā-sati, sammā-samādhi*—these eight factors are shown as the Noble Eightfold Path.

If we state this in the Sinhala language understandable to us, *sammā-diṭṭhi* means "right seeing" (or "right view"). Seeing here is not the vision seen by the eye. It is about the vision of life—the view regarding life. The view regarding the world. It can be called "right seeing". Next, *sammā-saṅkappa* means "right thoughts and aspirations" ("right intention"). Next, *sammā-vācā* means "right saying" ("right speech"). Right words. *sammā-kammanta* means "right doing" ("right action"). *sammā-ājīva* means "right living" ("right livelihood"). The method of maintaining life. Next, *sammā-vāyāma* means "right striving" ("right effort"). Energy. *sammā-sati* means "right recollecting" ("right mindfulness").

Recollecting in the correct way. *sammā-samādhī* means "right mind-unifying" ("right concentration"). Unifying the mind in the right way. Since time is insufficient to explain each of these at length, to mention briefly: *sammā-diṭṭhi* means that everyone has a vision of life. Even the criminal, everyone has some vision of life. Even the grasshopper has a vision of life—it ends in burning. Next, in that way, if someone's vision of life is correct, they can go towards development right from there. If someone's vision of life is wrong, there is downfall right from there. Thus, the first step is indeed the vision of life. That is shown in the Dhamma as *sammā-diṭṭhi*. That means, on one hand, if shown shallowly, if speaking only with reflection on this saṃsāra, understanding good and bad. Understanding wholesome and unwholesome deeds (*kusala* and *akusala*). In the world there are fruits of giving, etc. There are fruits and results of wholesome and unwholesome kamma, there is this world, there is the next world, there is mother, there is father, etc., shown as ten matters. A certain view that helps in doing wholesome deeds, doing merit. This is a view that helps one to go to a happy destination (*sugati*) instead of a miserable destination (*dugati*) in this saṃsāra.

But what goes even deeper than that is the Four Noble Truths. This entire saṃsāric existence, this very five aggregates (*pañcakkhandha*), is *Dukkha* (Suffering) as shown by the Tathāgata Fully Self-Awakened One. The cause of this *Dukkha* (Suffering) is *Taṇhā* (Craving). The place where this *Taṇhā* (Craving) thirst is stilled is Nibbāna. The path to that Nibbāna is this very Noble Eightfold Path. Understanding these Four Noble Truths is *sammā-diṭṭhi*. If someone's vision of life has been prepared in this way, a certain subtle transformation begins to take place within them systematically, little by little, from moment to moment. Just as when one climbs the first step, as one steps with one foot, the other foot is raised. Thus, if this view called *sammā-diṭṭhi*, this vision of life, has arisen in someone, a certain subtle transformation regarding thoughts and aspirations begins to occur systematically within them. That is shown as *nekkhamma-saṅkappa* (thought of renunciation), *abyāpāda-saṅkappa* (thought of non-ill-will), *avihiṃsā-saṅkappa* (thought of non-harming). That is, generally, *nekkhamma* means the idea of departing from the household life, the idea regarding renunciation of the household life. When speaking of this, one must not think that this is something belonging only to the monks. Renouncing the household life actually means that this saṃsāra is *Dukkha* (Suffering). Now, sometimes even lay devotees in troubled times declare that they want to ordain. At least in the deeper mind, there is some inclination towards ordination within these Buddhist devotees. Helping that is the sight of the monks, associating with the monks, and so on. On such occasions, what arises in these devotees is *nekkhamma-saṅkappa*. An idea regarding

departure. That is a wholesome thought. That is a wholesome mind. It is through the arising of thoughts regarding departure for an extremely long time that someone gets the strength even to ordain.

In that way, the mind is inclined towards the "**nekkhamma**" concept.

Abyāpāda-saṅkappa, that is, thoughts of loving-kindness, thoughts opposite to hatred. Next, **avihiṃsā-saṅkappa**, departing from violence and practicing non-violence. Thoughts of "may no being be harmed." These thoughts are called **sammā-saṅkappa**. Based on those thoughts, that person's words also change next. Those words mean striving to depart from lying, slander, harsh speech, and frivolous chatter. They try to abstain from those. In the **ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla** (eightfold virtue with livelihood as the eighth) observed on this occasion, this is spoken of. Next, while speaking those good words, abstaining from those bad ones, if they use truthful words, words that unite others, next, meaningful words, gentle words, then that person thinks: "My actions must also be in accordance with my words." They try to abstain from those wrongs called killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct. They try to abstain from destroying other lives, stealing, and sexual misconduct. This is **sammā-kammanta** (right action). That is "right doing."

Next, it does not stop there. Sometimes, a big problem for many people in this day and age is the question of livelihood, the path of living. From various places, from various big places, support is received for being dragged down to unrighteous paths. By that, the life of the Buddhist goes towards downfall in a huge way. So, **micchā-ājīva** means wrong livelihoods. Those must be abandoned. The Buddha pointed out, as things that must not be done by a Buddhist devotee, as livelihoods that must not be practiced: trade in weapons, trade in living beings for slaughter, trade in meat, trade in poisons, and trade in intoxicants. Abstaining from these, one must strive to establish a righteous livelihood. Otherwise, that Buddhist path of living, that matter of livelihood (**sammā-ājīva**), cannot be completed.

If someone has prepared their livelihood in this way, even with difficulty, even with some sacrifice, it does not go to waste. It is through the effort applied for that, next, through that effort, that person enters the plane of yoga, the plane of meditation, automatically. Automatically, they obtain the qualification to enter. For what does that person do through the effort made to prepare their livelihood, what is being done inside the mind? There is a big piece of work there. That is what is called **sammā-vāyāma** (right effort). That is the real striving. It is not a striving done in the world. It is a striving done inside the mind. What is that striving? The striving applied to prevent the arising of unarisen unwholesome states. The striving applied to abandon arisen unwholesome states. The striving

applied to generate unarisen wholesome states. Next, the striving applied to protect and consolidate arisen wholesome states. To consider briefly, within these four kinds of striving, there is an extremely great, valuable meditation. It is through the continuation of that meditation that *sammā-sati* (right mindfulness), what is called good recollecting, a good mindfulness, arises in that person. Just as if a watchman were given a job, "Do not let bad people enter here, if there are bad people, drive them away from here, bring good people close, treat them well"—if a watchman were given such a job, that person would have to do that work without sleeping, without falling into negligence. In that very same way is that great revolution occurring in the mind-stream of the devotee who strives regarding their livelihood. Because of that great transformation, that great energy, effort, and strive, a valuable virtue, an extremely rare virtue, arises in that person: *sammā-sati*. Real mindfulness, real recollecting.

When mindfulness emerges properly, what it directs itself to, when reflecting in accordance with the Dhamma, is the four establishments of mindfulness (*cattāro satipaṭṭhānā*). One begins to think about the nature of this body. About feelings (*vedanā*) [Feeling / Sensation] arising in this body, about the nature of this mind, about thoughts—arising, coming to the mind—about these. This is what is called the four establishments of mindfulness (*satipaṭṭhāna*). Those four establishments of mindfulness (*satipaṭṭhāna*) are the sole path (*ekāyanamagga*) to Nibbāna. The sole path, an unerring path, is those four establishments of mindfulness (*satipaṭṭhāna*). Thus, through the development of those establishments of mindfulness (*satipaṭṭhāna*), next, if someone has obtained the strength to maintain that mindfulness for a brief moment, as they gradually increase that duration, they can generate a certain concentration (*samādhi*). They can settle their mind. In that way, through right mind-unifying, they can unify the mind on a certain meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*). What is done by that is one-pointedness of mind (*cittakaggatā*). In this day and age, we use a word "personality" (*paurushaya*). To show the idea regarding someone's life, we say "personality". Indeed, personality emerges right here. Just like beginning to build a stupa and placing the pinnacle, if *sammā-samādhi* has arisen in some mind-stream, that person's personality becomes unified. Arriving at that state is what is called completing the Noble Eightfold Path.

If someone has completed that Noble Eightfold Path supramundanelly, right there is Nibbāna. How amazing is this Dhamma-path! The Buddha has declared: "This well-expounded Dhamma is directly visible (*sanditṭhika*), immediate (*akālika*), inviting one to come and see (*ehi-passika*), worthy of being applied (*opānāyika*), to be personally realized by the wise (*paccattam veditabbo

viññūhī*)." That is, this well-expounded Dhamma, the Dhamma-practices, are those of non-empty practice. It is a Dhamma containing an unerring practice that yields results directly. Because of that, it is well-expounded (*svākkhāta*).

Sandiṭṭhika (directly visible) means that in daily life, right in this life, before one's very eyes, one can see their results. Those can be implemented. As expressed in the manner "*thoka-thokam khaṇe pheṇe*", little by little, even starting slowly, there are results in proportion to what one does. Next, in that very same way, it yields results according to its immediate (*akālika*) nature. Especially, as we declared, when the Noble Eightfold Path is completed, right there is Nibbāna. There is no need for someone else to come and say, "Now you have completed it, so I will give you Nibbāna*." That is the immediate (*akālika*) nature of this Dhamma.

Next, *ehipassika* means "come and see." The Dhamma itself draws one in. The Buddha does not declare "come and see" as vendors on pavements invite people, "come and see." That is not the kind of thing shown by the Buddha here. It is the Dhamma itself that says, "come and see." Just like saying, "taste and see," it says, "put me into action in this way and see if there are results." That is the meaning of *ehipassika*—"come and see." Likewise, *opanayika* (worthy of being applied/leading inward) means it has a power of drawing one from one stage to another. We mentioned, according to the simile of the great ocean, it draws one from one to another. There is a systematic progression from one to another. Just as there is a connection from one step to another when climbing a flight of stairs. Therefore, if one has made a start at some point on this Dhamma-path, if one has made a proper start, a correct start, from that very point, that person has progress—not in vain, if they engage in it.

In that way, the Buddha shows the *ehipassika* and *opanayika* qualities. Next, *paccattaṃ veditabbo viññūhī*—for wise individuals, there is no need for someone else to come and tell them; they can put it into action and realize it for themselves, the Buddha declared. One must try it out and see whether there is a result of this Dhamma-path, whether this saṃsāra can be ended right in this life, in the manner called "*diṭṭheva dhamme*"—right in this life—whether that bliss of Nibbāna can be realized or not. Thus the Buddha declared here. Therefore, there is no reason for these lay devotees to hesitate regarding this Dhamma-path because of their lay status. In the past, even during the Buddha's time, Anāthapiṇḍika and others—when considering the wealthy of today, Anāthapiṇḍika was a person of hundreds of thousands of times greater wealth. Yet, he was a Stream-enterer (*sotāpanna*) lay disciple. The children of that lay prince also attained realization of the fruits of the path. The great laywoman Visākhā, next Citta the Householder, Hatthaka of Āḷavī, and so on—there is a

great number of names of laypeople among those who realized the fruits of the path.

Those devotees did not spend their time in vain. They utilized the real Dhamma-path at all times. They discussed the Dhamma with the Buddha, engaged in Dhamma and meditation; in that manner indeed did they spend their lives. In that way, Buddhist devotees who lead their lives successfully can reap the results from this Dhamma-path today as well. Therefore, you devotees must reflect: now, especially due to the works in one's life, many people hesitate in this day and age. Many say they cannot find time for these works. And because of that, they fall into negligence (*pamāda*).

This non-negligence (*appamāda*) is a fundamental word of the Buddha. Like the letter "A". These things cannot be postponed. That is, we hear many people saying, "Only after retiring can we do Dhamma and meditation." But after retiring, other problems arise next. Or else, due to physical weakness, one becomes unable to do them. Therefore, it is because of this postponing that we have traveled in this saṃsāra for such a long time. The Buddha, in order to generate fear of saṃsāra (*saṃsāra-bhaya*), on some occasions delivered amazing discourses. There is a collection of discourses called the "Anamatagga Saṃyutta". To thirty monks who had practiced Dhamma and meditation, who had arrived from the city of Pāvā, on one occasion the Buddha delivered an extremely moving, extremely amazing discourse. So powerful was that discourse that, at its conclusion, those monks became Arahants, it is declared. So, what kind of discourse did He deliver? This is how the Buddha began:

"Monks, this saṃsāra is so extremely long that its beginning point is not visible. A beginning point of this saṃsāra cannot be seen by anyone; of these beings who have traveled for an extremely long time, covered by ignorance (*avijjā*) and bound by craving (*taṇhā*) [Craving / Thirst], a beginning point is not visible." Next, He declares—asking a question of the monks—"Monks, what do you think? Traveling in this saṃsāra for such a long time, is the blood shed by you having your heads cut off greater, or is the water in the four great oceans greater?" The monks respectfully declare: "Venerable Sir, Blessed One, if we have understood the Dhamma preached by the Blessed One correctly, as we traveled in this saṃsāra during this extremely long time, the blood shed by us having our heads cut off is indeed greater; the water in the four great oceans is less." Next, the Buddha did not stop there: "Monks, when you were born as oxen, that is, born in the animal state of cattle, is the blood shed by having your heads cut off greater, or is the water in the four great oceans greater?"

On that occasion too, the monks had to reply in succession. Now, someone might think that this is a question about the blood shed by being born in various different births in this entire saṃsāra. But the Buddha asks, bringing up the matter regarding each individual animal: "Monks, when you were born as cows, born as buffaloes, born as goats, born as chickens, born as pigs, having your heads cut off, is the blood shed in each of those births greater, or is the water in the four great oceans greater?" To all of those, the monks reply: "Venerable Sir, Blessed One, if we have understood the Dhamma preached by the Blessed One correctly, that shed blood indeed is greater; the water in the four great oceans is not greater." Having replied in that way, by the time it concluded, how deeply did those monks understand the nature of saṃsāra!—They had arrived there without having attained any fruit of the path previously, but they had meditated well.—At the conclusion of that discourse, removing all the rust of defilements, they realized the extremely pure Nibbāna and ended the *Dukkha* (Suffering) of saṃsāra, it is mentioned.

Following that, you devotees must also reflect: as the bad side of this saṃsāra, there may be within many—even though you are currently lay devotees—wholesome Dhammas (*kusala-dhamma*) accumulated by living many lives as ascetics throughout endless time, or perhaps appearing as monks in previous Dispensations, regarding Dhamma and meditation. But, just like sparks under ashes, if one does not apply some effort, energy, towards them, one will never be able to do Dhamma and meditation, and will never be able to get results from them. Therefore, what we have to think is, generating the "perception of possibility," some strength may be present within us, we may have fulfilled certain perfections (*pāramīs*) in saṃsāra; relying on them, adding a present effort to them, traveling on this path of Dhamma, as the Buddha pointed out—just as wise individuals do—gradually, little by little, from moment to moment, just as the goldsmith removes the rust from silver, we must resolve to remove the rust of defilements present in our own mind-streams.

Today—as we stated—is the day of the Buddhist New Year. On a day like today, if one made such a resolution, calling to mind such a verse daily according to that resolution, keeping it as a motto, one would apply whatever small time one gets daily, even five or ten minutes before going to sleep. Now, what many people say is, "We have no free time." Government holidays and such are received in abundance. Free time is not something given; it is something one must obtain for oneself. Plenty of holidays are received. But one has no free time. Free time is something that must be obtained with effort. If the desire is there, if the speed called *saṃvega* (spiritual urgency) is there, if one trains in that Dhamma without negligence (*appamāda*), that person has time, has a moment, can make

a start, even little by little. Therefore, based on this Dhamma sermon, drawing your lives closer to the Dhamma-path, following the noble Dhamma-path, the Noble Eightfold Path pointed out by the Buddha, gradually, systematically practicing Dhamma, meditation, virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*), at some point, through the supramundane path-attainments of Stream-entry (*sotāpatti*), Once-returning (*sakadāgāmitā*), Non-returning (*anāgāmitā*), and Arahantship, you must pray to be liberated from this entire saṃsāric *Dukkha* (Suffering) and realize the noble, deathless, great Nibbāna. Even on this occasion, even while listening to this sermon, if you listened to the Dhamma from moment to moment with meditative attention (*manasikāra*), all unwholesome states in your minds were dispelled, they were removed, and instead, a mountain of wholesome thoughts, a mountain of refined wholesome thoughts, arose in your mind-stream on this occasion. You must pray that this mountain of wholesome thoughts may support the effort of realizing Nibbāna during this very lifetime, serving as a supporting condition (*upanissaya*) for realizing Nibbāna.

Likewise, now, this accumulated mountain of merit—if we too have gathered some mountain of merit in the form of preaching the Dhamma on this occasion, and you in the form of listening to the Dhamma—if there is a host of devas and Brahmas, such as the Sasana-protecting deities who are awake during this period of Sasana decline, the devas in this place, this sacred place—as you devotees know, Pahankanuwa is a particularly powerful place. If there are any deities or such states of existence residing in connection with such places, may all those who desire merit rejoice in this merit of listening to the Dhamma and preaching the Dhamma. Having rejoiced, may they be liberated from all saṃsāric *Dukkha* (Suffering) and realize the noble, supreme, peaceful, deathless, great Nibbāna through a preferred Bodhi (enlightenment state). We must share merits with those devas. Likewise, if there are any beings, from the Avīci hell to the Akaniṭṭha heaven, including your deceased relatives, who wish to receive merits, may all of them rejoice in this merit and be comforted by the noble, deathless, great Nibbāna. With this aspiration, recite these verses and share merits.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”